

CIPHER CITY — MISSION BRIEFINGS

Issue #1 • The Cybersecurity Innovation Hackathon

This is **not** a capture-the-flag and it's not a puzzle night. You're not here to break things for points. You're here to **find people who need protecting and build them something real**. Think of yourselves less as hackers and more as a founding team: by Sunday you should have a product — even a rough one — that a real customer would actually use, plus the story for why it matters and how it could survive past this weekend.

The one rule that governs every mission: build for a customer you can actually reach — yourself, your family, a neighbor, a local nonprofit, or a public tool everyone uses. *No mission requires access to a company's private systems or data.* If you can't name a real user and explain why they'd adopt it, it's not ready.

Bring your idea to life. Take it as far as your team can over the weekend — build it, code it, make it work. The further you push it, the stronger your demo. What ultimately wins, though, is the strength of the idea and how well it serves a real person, not the size of the codebase. A focused solution that genuinely helps someone can stand alongside a more ambitious one.

How you'll be judged:

1. **Real value** — does it solve a genuine problem for a real person? (*highest weight*)
2. **Customer fit** — is it clear who it's for and why they'd use it?
3. **Innovation** — is the approach fresh rather than a clone of something that already exists?
4. **Execution** — how well did you bring it to life and demo it?
5. **The pitch** — can you make us believe in it in three minutes?

Each arc is also judged through its own lens (stated at the top of the track).

ARC 1 — "SECRET IDENTITY"

Track: Privacy

Lens: how much real control you hand back to a person over their own data.

The opportunity: ordinary people have lost track of who holds their data and have no easy way to take it back. Whoever makes that simple has a product millions of people quietly want.

Mission 1.1 — “The Paper Trail”

The opportunity. Data brokers sell people’s name, address, phone, and habits. Almost no one knows they’re listed or how to get out — and the paid services that do this are expensive and shady. There’s room for a clean, trustworthy one. **Your customer.** Yourself and your family, as the first real users. **The challenge.** Build a tool that shows a person everywhere their data is exposed and helps them get it removed — ideally generating the opt-out requests and tracking which brokers actually delete the data.

Mission 1.2 — “Ghost in the App”

The opportunity. People tap “Allow” with no idea what an app collects. A simple “privacy nutrition label” anyone can read is something schools, parents, and app stores would all want. **Your customer.** Everyday smartphone users — and the parents buying kids their first phone. **The challenge.** Build a scanner that turns an app’s hidden data collection into a plain, scored “here’s what it sees” card anyone can understand — bonus if it recommends safer alternatives.

Mission 1.3 — “Burn After Reading”

The opportunity. A photo can leak your home, device, and timeline. A “clean this before you post” tool fits everyone from activists to teenagers — and it’s a natural browser or phone add-on. **Your customer.** Anyone who posts photos online. **The challenge.** Build a tool that strips and explains the hidden data in a photo or file before someone shares it, and warns about identifying details visible in the image itself.



Wildcard 1.X. Any product that gives a real person more visibility into or control over their own data.

ARC 2 — “PROJECT MYTHOS”

Track: AI Defense

Lens: does it make a powerful AI safe enough for a real business to put in front of customers?

The setup: Mythos — Cipher City’s powerful new AI — goes live this weekend, and every business in town wants to use it but is scared to. You don’t build Mythos. You build the

product that lets people adopt it safely — a market growing into the tens of billions.

Mission 2.1 — “The Whisperer”

The opportunity. Prompt injection — hijacking an AI with hidden instructions — is the #1 security risk for AI today. Every company adding a chatbot needs protection and most have none. **Your customer.** Any small business or developer adding an AI assistant. **The challenge.** Build a drop-in safety layer that sits in front of an AI chatbot, catches injection attacks, and shows in plain terms what it blocked.

Mission 2.2 — “Deepfake Heist”

The opportunity. Cloned-voice and deepfake fraud (“the boss called, wire the money”) is hitting families and small businesses now, and it especially preys on older adults. A simple verification product would sell itself. **Your customer.** Families and small teams targeted by impersonation scams. **The challenge.** Build a way to tell real from fake — either a detector for cloned voices/deepfakes, or a dead-simple verification service (safe-words, callbacks, one-tap checks) people can actually rely on.

Mission 2.3 — “Agent of Chaos”

The opportunity. AI agents now take real actions — send email, move money, run code. Businesses won’t deploy them until someone makes them controllable and auditable. That “safety dashboard” is a real B2B product. **Your customer.** Anyone wiring an AI up to do tasks for them. **The challenge.** Build a control panel that limits and logs what an AI agent is allowed to do, so a non-engineer can trust it to act on their behalf.

 **Wildcard 2.X.** Any product that lets people adopt powerful AI without getting burned by it.

ARC 3 — “NOBODY LEFT BEHIND”

Track: Accessible Security

Lens: inclusion — does it protect someone the security industry normally locks out?

The opportunity: the tools meant to keep us safe routinely shut out disabled and older users — CAPTCHAs and expiring login codes lock them out, and CAPTCHA isn’t even good security. A whole population is underserved, which means a whole market is too.

Mission 3.1 — “The Locked Door”

The opportunity. Inaccessible logins lock out millions of disabled and elderly users — and

businesses lose those customers at the door. An accessible, secure sign-in is something every website would want to license. **Your customer.** A visually-, motor-, or hearing-impaired user, or an older adult you can test with. **The challenge.** Build a secure sign-in or verification method that doesn't exclude people the way CAPTCHA and expiring codes do — and test it with a real user.

Mission 3.2 — “Plain Words”

The opportunity. Security advice is written in jargon, so people with low literacy, cognitive disabilities, or limited English stay unprotected. A plain-language safety helper could be adopted by libraries, senior centers, and schools. **Your customer.** Someone with limited tech literacy. **The challenge.** Build a simple, spoken, multi-language security helper — big text, clear yes/no, read-aloud — that explains threats and “is this a scam?” decisions to someone who finds normal security tools impenetrable.

Mission 3.3 — “Trusted Voice”

The opportunity. Urgency scams relentlessly target seniors. A product a whole family can set up for a parent — a safety net, not a lecture — is something adult children would gladly pay for. **Your customer.** An older adult in your life. **The challenge.** Build a scam safety net for an older adult — a paste-the-message checker and/or a “loop in my family” alert — designed around trust rather than lectures.



Wildcard 3.X. Any security product designed first for someone usually left out — by ability, age, language, or literacy.

ARC 4 — “DEFENDERS OF THE UNDERDOG”

Track: Nonprofits & Everyday People

Lens: deployability — could a broke, no-IT-staff organization actually adopt this on Monday?

The opportunity: nonprofits hold sensitive data, get attacked constantly, and two-thirds say their security is underfunded — yet enterprise tools are priced and built for enterprises. The product that's free, dead-simple, and made for them is wide open.

Mission 4.1 — “Phish & Chips”

The opportunity. Phishing is the most common and disruptive attack on charities, whose volunteers are rarely trained. A free, fun trainer made for non-technical volunteers is something thousands of small orgs need. **Your customer.** A local food bank, church, shelter, or small charity — go ask one what scares them. **The challenge.** Build a free,

genuinely engaging phishing-awareness trainer made for non-technical volunteers, and validate it by interviewing a real local nonprofit.

Mission 4.2 — “Fort Knox for Free”

The opportunity. A five-person nonprofit can’t buy or operate enterprise security. A guided “harden your free setup” product turns expensive expertise into a free walkthrough — adoptable by any small org or even a family. **Your customer.** A tiny nonprofit on a free Google Workspace or Microsoft 365 tier. **The challenge.** Build a guided tool that walks a non-technical admin through securing their setup step by step — MFA, backups, access review — mapped to the actual free-tier settings.

Mission 4.3 — “Did We Get Hit?”

The opportunity. Small orgs and ordinary people find out about breaches far too late. A plain-English “are we exposed, and what do we do now” product fits everyone from a charity to a worried parent. **Your customer.** A small organization or any individual. **The challenge.** Build a plain-English breach checker that tells a small org or individual whether they’re exposed and hands them a clear “what to do now” plan.



Wildcard 4.X. Any product a no-budget organization or an ordinary person could adopt this week.

HOW TO PICK

1. **Choose your arc** (the four tracks) — that sets the lens you’re judged on.
2. **Choose one mission**, or pitch a Wildcard within that arc.
3. **Name a real customer and prove you can reach them** — that’s your opening slide.
4. **Build it into something real** — take your idea as far as your team can over the weekend.
5. **Build toward the pitch.** By Sunday: what it is, who it’s for, why they’d adopt it, a demo, and how it could live past the weekend.

Find who needs defending. Build something real. Ship it.